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Newsom Signs AB 715, Law Targeting Antisemitism in California Schools

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After a nine-month battle, Governor Gavin Newsom (D) signed AB 715, legislation that aims to strengthen anti-discrimination protections in K–12 public schools on Oct. 7, the second anniversary of Hamas' attacks on Israel.

Newsom said the new law "establishes a new Office of Civil Rights and creates an Antisemitism Prevention Coordinator to develop training, resources, and enforcement strategies for K–12 schools." It "requires school districts to investigate and take corrective action when discriminatory content is used in classrooms or professional development," adding, "Every student in California deserves to feel safe, respected, and valued at school."

The law will create"distinct discrimination prevention coordinators, including the Antisemitism Prevention Coordinator, in an effort to ensure students are free from all forms of discrimination."

Newsom tied the law to his administration's earlier efforts, writing, "Antisemitism is a historic scourge and needs to be addressed aggressively, which is why my Administration established the Golden State Plan to Counter Antisemitism in April 2024." He noted that "in partnership with the Jewish Caucus and the Legislature, our combined efforts have led the Anti-Defamation League to recognize California as 'a national leader in combating antisemitism.'"

Acknowledging the months of debate that preceded the bill's passage, Newsom wrote, "Representatives from the entire education ecosystem — including teachers, administrators, school boards, school staff, students, and civil rights organizations — expressed deep commitment to the goals of the bill, along with urgent concerns about unintended consequences."

The bill had three goals: improving the state complaint process (Uniform Complaint Procedures), establishing a statewide antisemitism response role, and expanding the definition of protected categories in K–12 discrimination law. Proponents said these changes benefit all students, not only Jewish students.

AB 715 also expands the definition of "nationality" to include shared ancestry and perceived ties to ethnic or religious identity, clarifies that religious discrimination includes antisemitism and Islamophobia, and strengthens the process by allowing direct state intervention when local investigations stall.

California Legislative Jewish Caucus (CLJC)

The California Legislative Jewish Caucus (CLJC) celebrated the passage.

"Today, California is sending a strong and unambiguous message — hate has no place in our schools and will not be tolerated," Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D–Encino) and State Senator Scott Wiener (D–San Francisco), co-chairs of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, said. "We have been inspired by the leadership of our colleagues — and the incredible advocacy of Jewish students, parents, teachers, and leaders from across California — who fought tirelessly to protect Jewish children."

Assemblymembers Rick Chavez Zbur (D–Hollywood) and Dawn Addis (D–Morro Bay) authored the bill.

In July, Zbur told The Journal, "We've been trying to pass legislation like this for more than three years. We can't keep asking students to wait while hate incidents escalate in their schools. This bill benefits all students, not just Jewish students. When you strengthen complaint procedures and expand protections, you're improving the school climate across the board. AB 715 is the product of collaboration between the Legislative Diversity Caucuses. It

demonstrates solidarity and ensures that Jewish students, like every other student, have a safe and supportive school environment. … Jewish students deserve the same protections." After Newsom's signed the bill, Zbur said the law "demonstrates that the state will stand up for our Jewish students and community."

Addis said, "I'm a mom and a teacher and I couldn't be more grateful to Governor Newsom for signing AB 715. This is a historic first-in-the-nation effort that centers on the wellbeing of children across our state, many of whom bravely shared horrific stories about their experiences in our schools. When we hear what these kids and families have faced, it becomes impossible not to act."

At an August press conference, students and educators described incidents of harassment in California schools.

Elham, a Bay Area student, said, "They called me 'the Jew,' they told me that my family is living on stolen land and yelled at me that I was a murderer and a terrorist. … I had to run away for my own safety. Finally, at the end of the semester, my parents withdrew me from the public school and enrolled me in a private Jewish school."

Susie Sorkin, vice chair of the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California, said, "we finally have the chance to make major statewide reform to combat antisemitism in our schools. And when antisemitism is skyrocketing, we can't wait any longer. The time to pass AB 715 is now."

In a July 7 statement on X, the California Faculty Association, (CFA) expressed their opposition. "As educators, we will not be gaslit! … CFA is opposed to it, and we need you to call your senator to let them know. AB 715 does not protect—it silences." The CFA is "comprised of 29,000 educators from across the California State University system. The group objected to the concept of a state-appointed Antisemitism Coordinator and said AB 715 poses "a grave risk to all schools and districts."

The California Teachers Association (CTA), representing over 300,000 K-12 educators, also opposed AB 715.

In a July 3 letter to Pérez, although saying it was saying that while it "abhors and condemns antisemitism in any form," the group opposed AB 715. The bill would "impose limits and define standards for course instruction regarding Israel, Palestine, Zionism, or the Israeli/Palestinian conflict," in a way not applied to other global issues. The CTA also raised concerns about academic freedom.

A coalition of major Jewish organizations condemned the CTA for opposing the bill. In a joint statement on July 7, groups including the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California (JPAC), the Anti-Defamation League (ADL), the American Jewish Committee (AJC) and the Simon Wiesenthal Center. It accused the CTA of engaging in "hypocritical and misleading" tactics. "For years, the bill's authors have engaged in good faith with CTA leadership to address their concerns," the statement said. "Based on CTA's feedback, we have since removed provisions, revised language and narrowed the bill's scope — all while staying focused on protecting Jewish students. But each time we meet CTA's demands, the goalposts move."

An open letter circulated on June 17 by the Jewish Faculty Resilience Group (JFRG) touted over 1,200 signatories from faculty affiliated with California universities defending the bill. The letter said that "Curricula or teaching resources that discriminate or foster a hostile environment for Jewish or Israeli students must be rejected."

AB 715 (and its Senate counterpart, SB 48) unanimously passed both chambers. The measure presented to Governor Newsom on Sept. 24.

JPAC executive director David Bocarsly called the Oct. 7 signing "a historic day for California's Jewish community and for every child who has ever felt unsafe, unseen, or unwelcome at school … By signing AB 715, Governor Newsom has sent a clear and powerful message: antisemitism, like all forms of hate, has no place in our public schools, period. This law is more than policy – it is a promise that Jewish children, their families, and all students, deserve a great public education and classrooms free from hate and discrimination."

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